

She began the meet by congratulating the prime minister on his "historic achievement". Most noticed that she did not mention Pranab Mukherjee, the man who steered the deal through its roughest waters. And with the Congress it is always that what is left out is more important. The message down the rank was clear: the leadership of Manmohan was not to be questioned. Another glaring omission at the cwc was Home Minister Shivraj Patil's silence. He was not asked to speak from the dias. Nor did he want to.

Inflation is another worrying concern for the Congress, and another issue that the BJP is playing up. Unlike Patil, Finance Minister P. Chidambaram walked on to the dais and painstakingly explained that rising prices would soon be under control. A few minutes after the cwc ended, serial bombs exploded in Delhi. At a rally in Bangalore, the BJP raised its cry of a soft state a notch higher. "Terrorists have no fear because the Government is gripped with fear," said Advani. However, the BJP has realised that merely targeting Patil is not enough. Its spokesmen have been told to raise the level of its attack to Manmohan. "Elections are round the corner, after all," explained a party spokesman.

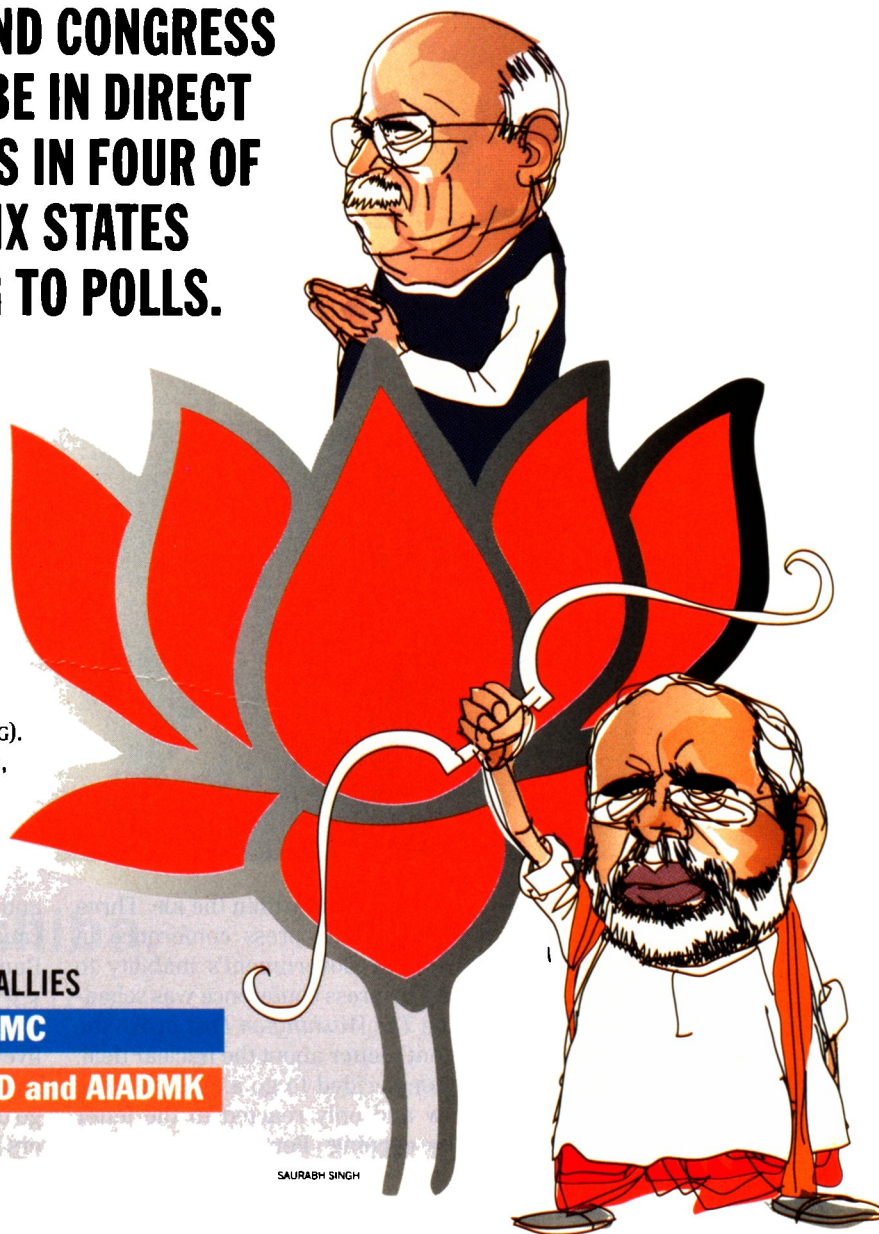
Despite all the feel-good rhetoric on the dais, Congress leaders are worried that unlike the BJP, it lacks an imaginative issue to sell to the *aam admi*. An appropriate slogan has been coined for the nuclear deal: "*Aap humko vote do, hum apko bijli denge* (give us your votes, we'll give you electricity)." But this still does not catapult the deal into the same rank as Indira Gandhi's *garibi hatao* war cry. This issue was raised by a group of youth workers from Chhattisgarh when they called on Rahul Gandhi who insisted that there should be no negative campaign against the state Government. When asked what achievements they should sell since the Congress is not in power in the state, Rahul suggested that they talk of the flagship schemes of the Central Government such as the National Rural Employment Guarantee (NREG). But the NREG is handed out by state governments, not by the Centre—it is Chhattisgarh Chief

Minister Raman Singh's smug smile and not Rahul's grin that is on the job cards handed out. The Congress does not get any credit in states where it is not in power. Unfortunately for it, the BJP rules in three of the states going to polls soon.

Both sides have also identified a star campaigner to sell their manifestoes. For the Congress, it is now Rahul's turn to work the family charm. While Manmohan will be the prime ministerial candidate, it is the Congress general secretary who is sitting in all the key meetings and deciding the tone of the party campaign. The BJP's prime ministerial choice is all too aware of this, which is why part of his campaign is aimed at the youth, despite his ripe old age of 80. "I don't see Advani's age as a disadvantage," says Sudheendra Kulkarni, a key party strategist. According to him, Advani's experience and struggle for India's democratic values will prove to be an inspiration for the youth.

This is going to be Advani's first—and perhaps

BJP AND CONGRESS WILL BE IN DIRECT FIGHTS IN FOUR OF THE SIX STATES GOING TO POLLS.



PLANKS

NREG, nuclear deal

Terrorism, inflation and nuclear sell-out

POSSIBLE ALLIES

SP and TMC

RLD, INLD and AIADMK

SAURABH SINGH